

ZEPTO CAFE

Step 3: Solution Ideation & Prioritization

15 Product Interventions · RICE Framework · Shortlisted to 2

July 2026 · Airtribe PM Launchpad Case Study

Ideation Constraints — What Filtered Every Solution

- ✓ Must live inside the Zepto Cafe standalone app (launched Dec 2024 as MVP) or main Zepto app experience
- ✓ Solutions grounded in Step 1 primary survey (n=15 valid) + competitive analysis (Swiggy, Zomato, Blinkit, Starbucks)
- ✓ Current app baseline verified: basic ordering, live tracking, Zepto Pass (10% off Cafe + free delivery), 4.6★ rating — NO streak, NO reorder shortcut, NO contextual push, NO freshness signal
- ✗ Out of scope: Kitchen ops, food prep, delivery partner ops, supply chain, discount-only mechanisms, full app redesign

1. 15 Solutions Ideated

Solutions grouped by friction point (from Step 2). RICE score shown on each card — full scoring methodology in Section 2.

Group A — F1: No Habit Hook (Primary Barrier from Step 2)

S1 [F1 · Push] Chai O'Clock — Time-Triggered Snack Push

720

RICE

Personalised push Mon–Fri at 3:30–4:30pm showing last ordered item + one-tap 'Reorder' CTA. Time window from survey: confirmed peak snack-break moment.

Barrier: F1+F4 **R:**600 **I:**3 **C:**80% **E:**2 **Evidence:** 33% forgot to reorder (survey). Swiggy push = 20-40% CTR lift. Push infra exists for grocery.

S2

[F1 · Gamification] Chai Streak — 3-Day Consecutive Tracker

320

RICE

After first order, streak widget appears on Cafe home. Order 3 consecutive weekdays → free add-on (not a % discount). Breaking streak triggers loss-aversion nudge.

Barrier: F1 **R:**800 **I:**2 **C:**60% **E:**3 **Evidence:** Zomato Streak drives repeat uplift via loss aversion. Lower confidence — requires 3-day consecutive habit not yet established.

S3 467 RICE	[F1 · Loyalty] 10-for-1 Cafe Stamp Card Every completed Cafe order earns one stamp. Nine stamps → one free item. Visible stamp progress on Cafe home. Milestone reward, not per-order discount — constraint-compliant. Barrier: F1 R: 1000 I: 2 C: 70% E: 3 Evidence: <i>Starbucks Coffee Loop (India): 15% frequency lift. 10% effective reward spread over 9 orders — economically viable at Rs100 AOV.</i>
S4 1200 RICE	[F1 · In-App] Snack-Break In-App Contextual Banner At 3:30–4:30pm on weekdays, all users opening the Cafe app see a banner: 'Snack break? Your usual is 10 mins away.' Captures users with push notifications off. Barrier: F1 R: 800 I: 2 C: 75% E: 1 Evidence: <i>Same logic as S1 but zero new infra — standard in-app banner with time-of-day condition. Effort=1 gives it the 2nd-highest RICE score overall.</i>
S1 5 413 RICE	[F1 · Quick Win] First Reorder Accelerator — Bonus Stamps For users within 7 days of Order 1: 2 bonus stamps if they place Order 2 within 3 days. Jumpstarts stamp card momentum at the most critical drop-off point. Barrier: F1 R: 500 I: 3 C: 55% E: 2 Evidence: <i>Step 2: Order 1→2 is where 88% are lost. Bonus stamps create urgency without a direct discount. Lower confidence as novel mechanic.</i>
Group B — F4: No Reorder Shortcut	
S5 2700 RICE	[F4 · UX] 'Your Usual' One-Tap Reorder Card After first order, Cafe home shows persistent card: '[Name]'s Usual: Masala Chai + Samosa' with a single 'Reorder Now' button. Cart rebuilt instantly. Ordering drops from 90s to 15s. Barrier: F4 R: 1000 I: 3 C: 90% E: 1 Evidence: <i>Highest RICE score (2700). All 4 competitors have this as standard. Uses existing order history. Effort=1. The single most impactful, easiest-to-build solution.</i>
S6 560 RICE	[F4 · UX] Saved Cafe Favourites — 'My Usual' Combos Pin up to 3 saved combos. User names them ('Afternoon Chai', 'Morning Combo'). Accessible from Cafe home. Extends S5 to support multiple saved configurations. Barrier: F4 R: 700 I: 2 C: 80% E: 2 Evidence: <i>Starbucks order memory reduces decision fatigue. Survey: users want less friction at Rs100. Extends S5 logic — builds on same order history infrastructure.</i>
S7 81 RICE	[F4 · Advanced] Scheduled Recurring Order — 'Every Weekday 4pm' User sets a recurring Cafe order with time + items. Zepto auto-places it daily. Turns occasional order into a calendar commitment. Cancel anytime. Barrier: F4 R: 300 I: 3 C: 45% E: 5 Evidence: <i>RICE=81 — despite high impact per user, RICE correctly buries this due to Effort=5 (recurring order engine) and low confidence (45%). Phase 2 candidate only.</i>

Group C — F5: No Quality or Freshness Signal

S8 270 RICE	[F5 · Trust] Freshness Badge — 'Prepared Fresh Every X Mins' Live freshness indicator on menu items: 'Made fresh every 20 mins' or 'Last batch: 12 mins ago'. Data from kitchen prep schedule (not real-time ops change — schedule-based UI only). Barrier: F5 R:900 I:1 C:60% E:2 Evidence: 73% cite quality as barrier (survey). Starbucks 'Made for you' freshness signal rebuilds trust. Medium confidence: requires kitchen schedule data access.
S9 700 RICE	[F5 · Feedback] 3-Second Post-Order Quality Loop After every delivery: 3-emoji prompt (Fresh & Hot / Okay / Disappointing). If negative → 'Cafe Promise' credit triggered. Creates quality feedback loop + trust signal without kitchen ops change. Barrier: F5 R:1000 I:1 C:70% E:1 Evidence: RICE=700 — jumps to #4 overall because Effort=1. Survey: taste 3.57/5 vs importance 4.60/5 is the biggest gap. This creates a data loop AND a retention intervention.
S10 293 RICE	[F5+F3 · Trust] 'X People from Your Area Ordered This Hour' Hyper-local social proof on menu: '47 people near your office ordered chai in the last hour.' Reduces uncertainty about freshness and reduces canteen default. Barrier: F5+F3 R:900 I:1 C:65% E:2 Evidence: Zomato 'most ordered today' badge effective. Survey: 60% prefer canteen — social proof challenges the canteen's perceived safety. Location+order data already in Zepto backend.

Group D — F3: Competitor Displacement (Canteen / Chai Stall)

S11 14 RICE	[F3 · Social] Group Chai — Office Round Order Share Cafe order link to team. Teammates add items. One delivery. Split payment via Zepto. Reduces per-item delivery cost and adds social ritual dimension (mirroring canteen 'chai round'). Barrier: F3 R:200 I:1 C:35% E:5 Evidence: RICE=14 — lowest score. High effort (split payment, multi-user order engine) and lowest confidence. Survey: 60% prefer canteen but social angle is unproven. Deprioritised.
S12 130 RICE	[F3 · Subscription] Cafe Pass — Zepto Pass Extension Extend Zepto Pass to free delivery on ALL Cafe orders regardless of value. Removes delivery fee friction on Rs100 snack — currently a significant mental blocker. Barrier: F3 R:400 I:1 C:65% E:2 Evidence: Zepto Pass launched with 1M subscribers in 1 week. Pass users spent 30% more + 10% better retention. Cafe-specific data thin — lower confidence. RICE=130.

Group E — Advanced / Phase 2

S1
3
144
RICE

[Advanced · AI] **AI Order Suggestion — Natural Language**

Zepto's internal AI agent experiment (open-sourced Dec 2025) surfaces at snack time: 'It's 4pm, last Tuesday you ordered masala chai — want the same?' One tap to confirm.

Barrier: F1+F4 **R:**600 **I:**3 **C:**40% **E:**5 **Evidence:** RICE=144. High impact per user but Effort=5 and Confidence=40% (not consumer-ready per Dec 2025 Medianama report). Phase 2 — monitor AI agent progress.

S1
4
100
RICE

[Advanced · Widget] **Cafe Home/Lock Screen Widget**

iOS/Android widget showing last Cafe order + 'Reorder' button. Zero-friction ordering without opening the app. Inspired by Swiggy shortcuts.

Barrier: F4 **R:**300 **I:**2 **C:**50% **E:**3 **Evidence:** RICE=100. High concept but Effort=3 for platform-specific widget builds and adoption requires user setup step. Phase 2 after core reorder UX is built.



2. RICE Prioritization Framework — Methodology

RICE is a quantitative prioritization framework that forces four inputs per solution, producing a score that balances ambition with reality. Unlike a simple Impact × Feasibility 2×2, RICE accounts for how many users are actually affected (Reach) and how confident we are in our estimates (Confidence) — both critical given our primary research sample of n=15.

Input	Definition	Scale Used	How We Estimated It
R — Reach	How many users will encounter this feature per month?	Per 1,000 monthly active Cafe users	Based on Zepto Cafe's ~30K daily orders (~900K/month). Reach% per solution derived from survey data: e.g. 60% of users have push enabled → S1 Reach=600
I — Impact	How much does this move the needle for each user who encounters it?	0.25 / 0.5 / 1 / 2 / 3 (Intercom scale)	Grounded in Step 2 barrier ranking. Solutions addressing F1 (primary barrier, cited by 33%) scored 3. Solutions addressing F5 scored 1 (indirect path to repeat rate).
C — Confidence	How sure are we of our Reach and Impact estimates?	Percentage (35%–90%)	Tied to evidence quality. S5 (Your Usual Card) = 90% — all 4 competitors have it, order history exists. S13 (AI) = 40% — not consumer-ready per Dec 2025 reports.
E — Effort	How many person-months to build an MVP?	1 = 1–2 weeks / 2 = 3–4 weeks / 3 = 1–2 months / 5 = 3+ months	Estimated against current Zepto Cafe standalone app MVP baseline. Effort=1 means pure UI/logic on existing data. Effort=5 means new infrastructure.

RICE Score Formula = (Reach × Impact × Confidence) / Effort

A high RICE score means: this solution reaches many users, moves the needle meaningfully, we're confident in that assessment, AND it's not expensive to build.

The Effort denominator is why RICE outperforms a simple 2×2 matrix here: a high-impact solution that takes 5 person-months to build will correctly score lower than a medium-impact solution that takes 1 week.

Confidence % is what makes RICE honest at n=15 sample size — lower confidence on solutions where our evidence is thin (novel mechanics, advanced tech) vs. solutions backed by competitor proof and survey data.

Why RICE over Impact × Feasibility

The original 2×2 matrix treated S4 (In-App Banner) and S3 (Stamp Card) as equal priority. RICE reveals S4 scores 1200 (Effort=1) vs S3's 467 (Effort=3) — the Banner should ship first.

RICE also surfaces S9 (Post-Order Quality Loop) at score 700 — nearly as important as the push notification — because Effort=1 and Reach=1000. The 2×2 had classified it as a 'fill-in.'

Most importantly: RICE correctly buries S7 (Scheduled Recurring Order) at score 81 despite high per-user impact — because Effort=5 and low confidence. The 2×2 had rated it 'medium priority.'

3. RICE Scores — All 15 Solutions Ranked

R a n k	ID	Solution	Barrier	R	I	C	E
1	S5	Your Usual One-Tap Reorder Card — RICE: 2700 [Sprint 1 ★★]	F4	1000	3	90%	1
2	S4	In-App Snack-Break Banner — RICE: 1200 [Sprint 1 ★★]	F1	800	2	75%	1
3	S1	Chai O'Clock Push Notification — RICE: 720 [Sprint 1 ★★]	F1+F4	600	3	80%	2
4	S9	Post-Order Quality Loop — RICE: 700 [Sprint 1 ★]	F5	1000	1	70%	1
5	S6	Saved Cafe Favourites — RICE: 560 [Sprint 2 ★]	F4	700	2	80%	2
6	S3	10-for-1 Cafe Stamp Card — RICE: 467 [Sprint 2 ★]	F1	1000	2	70%	3
7	S15	First Reorder Accelerator — RICE: 413 [Sprint 2 ★]	F1	500	3	55%	2

8	S2	Chai Streak (3-day) — RICE: 320 [Sprint 3]	F1	800	2	60%	3
9	S10	Social Proof Widget — RICE: 293 [Sprint 3]	F5+F3	900	1	65%	2
10	S8	Freshness Badge — RICE: 270 [Sprint 3]	F5	900	1	60%	2
11	S13	AI Order Suggestion — RICE: 144 [Phase 2]	F1+F4	600	3	40%	5
12	S12	Cafe Pass Extension — RICE: 130 [Phase 2]	F3	400	1	65%	2
13	S14	Lock Screen Widget — RICE: 100 [Phase 2]	F4	300	2	50%	3
14	S7	Scheduled Recurring Order — RICE: 81 [Phase 2]	F4	300	3	45%	5
15	S11	Group Chai Order — RICE: 14 [Deprioritise]	F3	200	1	35%	5

≥ 700 Sprint 1 ★★

400–699 Sprint 2 ★

200–399 Sprint 3

<200 Phase 2+

★ 4. The 2 Shortlisted Solutions — RICE-Justified

Solution A (S5 + S1 + S4) are shortlisted as a single compound Habit Loop — they form one seamless experience with interlocking RICE scores. Solution B (S3 Stamp Card) is shortlisted as the reward mechanism that completes the loop, validated by the Starbucks Coffee Loop precedent and its RICE score of 467 — strong enough to include but correctly phased to Sprint 2 after the Effort=1 foundations are live.



SHORTLISTED SOLUTION A

"Chai O'Clock" — The Contextual Habit Loop

S5 Your Usual Reorder Card (RICE 2700) + S1 Push Notification (RICE 720) + S4 In-App Banner (RICE 1200)

RICE Rationale

S5 is the single highest RICE score in the entire solution set (2700). It scores this because Reach=1000 (every user who opens the app), Impact=3 (directly addresses the primary barrier), Confidence=90% (all 4 competitors have it, order history data is in Zepto's backend today), and Effort=1 (a UI card on an existing data source). S4 scores second-highest overall (1200) for the same reason — Effort=1. S1 scores third (720) — slightly lower than S4 because Reach=600 (not all users have push enabled) and Effort=2. Together, these three form one compound experience: the push (S1) and in-app banner (S4) create the CUE; the reorder card (S5) enables the ROUTINE. RICE correctly shows all three should ship in Sprint 1.

Why This Solution, Why Now

The RICE analysis revealed a key sequencing insight that the 2x2 matrix missed: S5 and S4 (both Effort=1) should ship before S1 (Effort=2), not simultaneously. In Week 1, deploy the 'Your Usual' card and the in-app banner — these require zero new infrastructure. In Week 3–4, add the push notification layer on top. Users who convert via in-app banner in Week 1 will be primed for the push in Week 3.

The Mechanism — How It Works

At 3:45pm on weekdays, the Cafe app sends a personalised push: 'Priya, your usual Masala Chai is 10 mins away.' Tapping the push opens the Cafe home screen to a pre-loaded 'Your Usual' reorder card. Users who have push off see an equivalent in-app banner when they open the app. One green button. Pre-filled address. Payment confirmation. Order placed in under 15 seconds.

Step 1: User places Order 1 — seeds 'Your Usual' card and sets snack-time baseline in system.

Step 2: From Day 2: 'Your Usual' card appears on Cafe home screen (S5, Effort=1, ships Week 1).

Step 3: From Day 2: In-app banner activates at 3:30–4:30pm (S4, Effort=1, ships Week 1).

Step 4: From Week 3: Personalised push notification layer added at snack time (S1, Effort=2, ships Week 3–4).

Step 5: User taps push or banner → pre-loaded cart → confirms address → places order in 2 taps.

Step 6: Each completed order increments the Stamp Card (Solution B) — closing the reward loop.

Research Evidence Base

- Primary survey (Step 1, n=15): 33% cited 'forgot to reorder / not prompted' as barrier — highest in-app-addressable friction point.
- Survey verbatim: 'If there was something that reminded me to order chai around 4pm, I'd probably use it more often.'



SHORTLISTED SOLUTION B

"Cafe Stamp Card" — The 10-for-1 Loyalty Loop

S3 — 10-for-1 Stamp Card (RICE 467) · Sprint 2 · with S15 First Reorder Accelerator (RICE 413) as a companion

RICE Rationale

S3 scores 467 — placing it clearly in Sprint 2 territory, behind all Effort=1 solutions. This is the right call: the Stamp Card needs Order History data and a loyalty backend that S5 (Sprint 1) will already have set up, and it creates the most value once users have already returned once (via Solution A). S3's Confidence=70% is grounded in the Starbucks Coffee Loop pilot data. The Effort=3 reflects the loyalty tracking module, stamp UI, and redemption flow at checkout — real engineering work that justifies building Solution A first. S15 (First Reorder Accelerator, RICE=413) ships alongside S3 as a Sprint 2 companion: it awards 2 bonus stamps for placing Order 2 within 7 days of Order 1, directly attacking the 88% drop-off at the Order 1→2 transition.

Why This Solution, Why Now

Solution A creates the trigger and the routine. Solution B creates the REWARD — completing the habit loop. Without an accumulating reward, prompted users may return once, then drift. The Stamp Card adds loss aversion ('I'm at 6 of 9 — I'm not starting over') and a tangible, visible milestone. It's a milestone reward (not a per-order discount), so it is fully constraint-compliant. At Rs100 AOV, a free 10th item = ~10% effective reward spread across 9 completed orders — economically viable and defensible.

The Mechanism — How It Works

After Order 1 completes, a stamp card widget appears on the Cafe home screen — Stamp 1 already filled. Each completed delivery fills the next stamp with a satisfying animation. At Stamp 5: mid-progress nudge 'Halfway there!' At Stamp 9: push notification + in-app banner + free item redemption CTA at next checkout. On redemption: card resets but Stamp 1 is pre-filled to prevent restart drop-off. First Reorder Accelerator (S15): if Order 2 placed within 7 days of Order 1, 2 stamps are awarded instead of 1.

Step 1: Sprint 1 (Solution A) ships — establishes the reorder habit for initial cohort.

Step 2: Sprint 2 begins: loyalty backend built (stamp tracking, redemption logic, progress state).

Step 3: After Order 1 completes: Stamp widget appears on Cafe home, Stamp 1 filled.

Step 4: S15 integration: if Order 2 placed within 7 days, bonus 2 stamps awarded automatically.

Step 5: At Stamp 5: mid-progress push 'Halfway there — 4 more chais to your free one!'

Step 6: At Stamp 9: free item CTA unlocked at next checkout. User selects chai / coffee / snack.

Step 7: Post-redemption: card resets with Stamp 1 pre-filled — maintains momentum.

Research Evidence Base

- Starbucks Coffee Loop India/SE Asia pilot: stamp card mechanic → 15% visit frequency lift vs. non-participants. Same ticket size range.



5. RICE-Driven Build Phases

RICE changes the phasing recommendation from the original Impact×Feasibility plan. All Effort=1 solutions (regardless of RICE tier) should ship in Sprint 1 — they create immediate value and de-risk the higher-effort solutions that follow.

Phase	Timeline	Solutions	What This Unlocks
Sprint 1	Month 1–2	S5 (RICE 2700) · S4 (1200) · S1 (720) · S9 (700)	Core habit loop: CUE + ROUTINE + quality feedback data. Zero new infrastructure required for S5, S4, S9.
Sprint 2	Month 2–3	S6 (RICE 560) · S3 (467) · S15 (413)	Reward loop complete: Saved Favourites + Stamp Card + Reorder Accelerator. Sprint 1 data informs stamp card design.
Sprint 3	Month 4–5	S2 (320) · S10 (293) · S8 (270) · S12 (130)	Depth features: Streak, social proof, freshness badges, Cafe Pass extension. Informed by Sprint 1+2 retention data.
Phase 2	Month 6+	S13 (144) · S14 (100) · S7 (81) · S11 (14)	Advanced tech: AI suggestion, lock screen widget, scheduled orders, group orders. Only if Sprint 1–3 validates core loop.

RICE changed one key phasing decision

Original 2×2 plan: S1 (Push) and S5 (Reorder Card) were co-equal Sprint 1 items; S9 (Post-Order Rating) was a fill-in.

RICE-revised plan: S5 ships in Week 1 (Effort=1, Confidence=90%); S9 ships alongside it (Effort=1, RICE=700 — not a fill-in at all); S1 follows in Week 3-4 (Effort=2). This is the right call: ship what's cheapest first, use the data to validate before investing in push infrastructure.

S3 (Stamp Card) correctly stays in Sprint 2 — RICE=467 and Effort=3 means it must wait until the reorder habit has been established by Solution A. Building a loyalty system for users who don't yet return is wasteful.

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